SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #39 · FORGIVENESS

“God has forgiven me, but I can never forgive myself.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A mistake that caused real harm to someone you love. High personal standards that make failure feel unbearable. Replaying the past over and over. Feeling that letting yourself off the hook would mean you don’t care. Shame that is deeper than guilt: not just “I did wrong,” but “I am wrong.”

What Scripture teaches

If God, the Judge of all, has forgiven you, no one, including you, has the right to keep condemning you. “Who will bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies.” Refusing to accept God’s verdict can quietly set your own judgment above His. Paul, who had persecuted Christians, chose to forget what was behind and press on. Accepting forgiveness does not mean the wrong did not matter; it means you trust that Christ’s payment was enough.

> *“Who will bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies”* **(Romans 8:33)**.

Also see

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” **(Romans 8:1)**.

> “Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus” **(Philippians 3:13–14)**.

> “As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us” **(Psalm 103:12)**.

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” **(2 Corinthians 5:17)**.

Common self-statements

- I’ll never forgive myself for what I did.
- God may have forgiven me, but I can’t.
- If I let it go, it means I don’t care.
- I have to keep feeling bad to show I’m sorry.
- I don’t deserve peace.
- I am the worst person I know.

Common logical errors

- **Double standard:** Accepting God’s forgiveness for others but refusing it for yourself.
- **Setting yourself above God:** Treating your judgment as higher than God’s verdict.
- **Labeling:** Defining yourself by your worst moment.
- **Rumination:** Replaying the past as if more replaying could change it.

Challenging questions

- If God has forgiven me, whose judgment am I following?
- Is my standard higher than God's?
- What does Romans 8:33 say about anyone who brings a charge against me?
- Is replaying this making anything better?
- Would I tell a friend in my place that they can never forgive themselves?
- What did Paul do with his terrible past?
- What could I do now to honor God instead of punishing myself?

Truth summary

> If God has forgiven me, I can accept His verdict. My judgment is not higher than His. Christ's payment was enough. I can grieve what I did, make amends where possible, and then forget what is behind and press on toward what God has ahead. I am a new creation.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Grace
- Born Again

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God has forgiven me, but I can never forgive myself"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God has forgiven me, but I can never forgive myself." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose judgment am I following?
- ☐ Is my standard higher than God's?
- ☐ Who can bring a charge against me if God justifies?
- ☐ Is replaying this making anything better?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend in my place?
- ☐ What did Paul do with his past?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ If God has forgiven me, I can accept His verdict.
- ☐ It is God who justifies me.
- ☐ Christ's payment was enough.
- ☐ I can forget what is behind and press on.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ Jesus.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Romans 8:33**
  "Who will bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies."
- [ ] **Romans 8:1**
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- [ ] **Philippians 3:13–14**
  "Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God's heavenly calling in Christ Jesus."
- [ ] **Psalm 103:12**
  "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us."
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 5:17**
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"

A verse I found myself: _____

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Press on log:** Each day, write one way I moved forward instead of replaying the past.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Philippians 3:13–14 becomes: "But one thing **Sarah** does: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, **she** presses on toward the goal to win the prize of God's heavenly calling in Christ Jesus."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write a letter to yourself** from God's point of view, using Romans 8:1 and 8:33, and read it aloud.
- ☐ **If possible, make amends for the wrong,** then write "Done" and stop revisiting it.
- ☐ **When the memory returns, set a timer for two minutes to pray about it,** then turn to a useful task.
- ☐ **Do one act of kindness for someone else this week** as a way of pressing on.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God has forgiven me, but I can never forgive myself": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One step I took forward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God has forgiven me, but I can never forgive myself.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You have forgiven me completely. Help me reject the lie that I can never forgive myself. I accept Your verdict over my own. Help me grieve what I did, make it right where I can, and then press on toward what You have ahead for me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

✦ ✦ ✦

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.